

Q What's the best way to give my baby his bottle?

First, get comfortable yourself, sitting upright with your back straight and supported. Feeding can take a while, so you don't want to strain your back.

Hold your baby close to you, cradling him against your body and facing you, so you can talk and make eye contact during a feeding. It's a wonderful chance to bond with your baby. Keep him upright holding him at your chest height, since this will help him swallow at a steady pace. Allow him to pause during a

feeding if he wants (as he would naturally when breast-feeding), then resume. If he squirms or seems restless midway through, remove the bottle and try burping him, then continue when he has settled. It's important that you never leave your baby with a bottle propped up in his mouth since he could suffocate or choke.

THINGS TO REMEMBER

» **Watch out** for signs that he is feeding too quickly: if he gulps down a bottle and milk seeps out the corner of his mouth, the milk may be flowing too quickly and he needs a slower-release nipple.

» **Don't encourage** your baby to finish a bottle if he appears to have lost interest. He is probably full and encouraging him to continue could make him uncomfortable.

HOW TO BOTTLE-FEED STEP BY STEP

By following these simple steps you will soon become a natural at giving a bottle. It will quickly turn into a familiar routine that you and your baby both enjoy.



1 Gently rub his cheek to encourage the rooting reflex. Then place the nipple so that it is touching his top lip. Don't push the nipple into his mouth, wait for him to open his mouth to take it, or gently nuzzle it against his lips to encourage him to take it.



2 Hold the bottle slightly upright, making sure the milk covers the opening of the nipple and the neck of the bottle. This will help to make sure that your baby isn't taking in too much extra air during a feeding. Support your baby's head with the cradle of your arm.



3 Tilt the bottle up a bit more as the bottle empties so that the milk continues to cover the nipple. At the end of a feeding you can put your little finger (make sure it's clean) into your baby's mouth to break off the suction and remove the bottle.

Q I am breast-feeding and plan to introduce a bottle. Any tips on making this switch?

While some babies switch from breast to bottle without a hitch, others go into a screaming meltdown. If your baby protests loudly whenever a bottle comes near him, there are a few tactics you can try. Getting your partner to

give a bottle means that your baby can't smell your milk. Choose a time when your baby isn't very hungry, perhaps an afternoon feeding, so that he is less likely to get distressed if he isn't getting the milk he wants. If you're not in a rush to get him onto formula, you could try giving expressed milk first, since he may be more willing to try a bottle if the contents are familiar.

Keep in mind, too, that breast-fed babies need to suck harder to get their milk, so starting

off with a slow-flow nipple can help ensure your baby isn't overwhelmed by a fast flow of milk. Conversely, if your baby is very hungry, a slower flow may frustrate him. Experiment to find the nipple that suits him. Let your baby play with and get used to the bottle, and don't continue trying if he refuses after about three attempts. Take a break, offer a breast-feed after about 10 minutes, then try the bottle again in a few days.